

CHOOSING A DIGITAL ARCHIVE OR EXHIBIT PLATFORM FOR YOUR PROJECT

A workshop in the “Digital Humanist’s Help Desk” series

September 25, 2026

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Follow along with links at: [**https://canva.link/2026-rdds-digital-archive**](https://canva.link/2026-rdds-digital-archive)

OVERVIEW

Many options exist for creating digital archives and digital exhibits for your research in the humanities. This session will guide participants through the pros and cons of various free and paid digital archive and exhibit tools and platforms like WordPress, Omeka, CollectionBuilder, ArcGIS Storymaps, Quire, and Wax. Special attention will be paid to evaluating your own source material, needs, and priorities to find the best tool for you and your project.

Learning goals:

- *Identify what kind of humanities data and source material you have (or want) to create a digital project that emulates an archive or exhibit.*
- *Evaluate your resources and constraints relevant to choosing a tool.*
- *Apply this knowledge to planning to create your own projects using the most appropriate tool(s) for your needs.*

WHO AM I?

Cynthia Heider



Public Digital Scholarship Librarian

Email: heider@upenn.edu

Book a consultation:

www.library.upenn.edu/staff/cynthia-heider

What can I help with?

- Digital projects for public audiences
- Digital projects involving community partners
- Choosing the right tool or platform for your digital project
- Working with data in the humanities
- Connecting with digital project resources at and beyond UPenn

Research Data and Digital Scholarship (RDDS)

- Support across research data & digital scholarship lifecycles
- Encourage thoughtful and informed use of emerging technologies in our fields of expertise
- Aid in the creation & dissemination of traditional + cutting-edge scholarly outputs
- Provide custom workshops, in-class visits, and consultations (one-on-one or team-based).

Website: www.library.upenn.edu/RDDS

Email: LibraryRDDS@pobox.upenn.edu

Workshop calendar: bit.ly/RDDS-events

ROADMAP



Pre-planning your project

Resource mapping

Reviewing your project's needs and priorities

Platform roundup

Questions and comments

PRE- PLANNING

*What materials are you working with? What are your
ideas for your project?*

HUMANITIES RESEARCH DATA

What does data look like in the humanities?

- correspondence
estate inventory
shipping manifest
diary or journal
financial ledger
photograph
drawing or other work of visual art
burial, birth, or wedding record
newspaper
property record or deed
tax list
notebook
memorandum
telegram
speech
material culture item
genealogy
recipe or menu
film, novel, or other cultural artifact
- directory
logbook
blueprints
built structure
price list
advertisement
legislation
government proceedings
transcript
interview
autobiography
schematic or plan
diagram or chart
land survey or map
polling results
census
audio or video recording
publication

... and more!

EXERCISE: PRE-PLANNING

Choosing a Digital Platform for Your Project

Pre-planning:

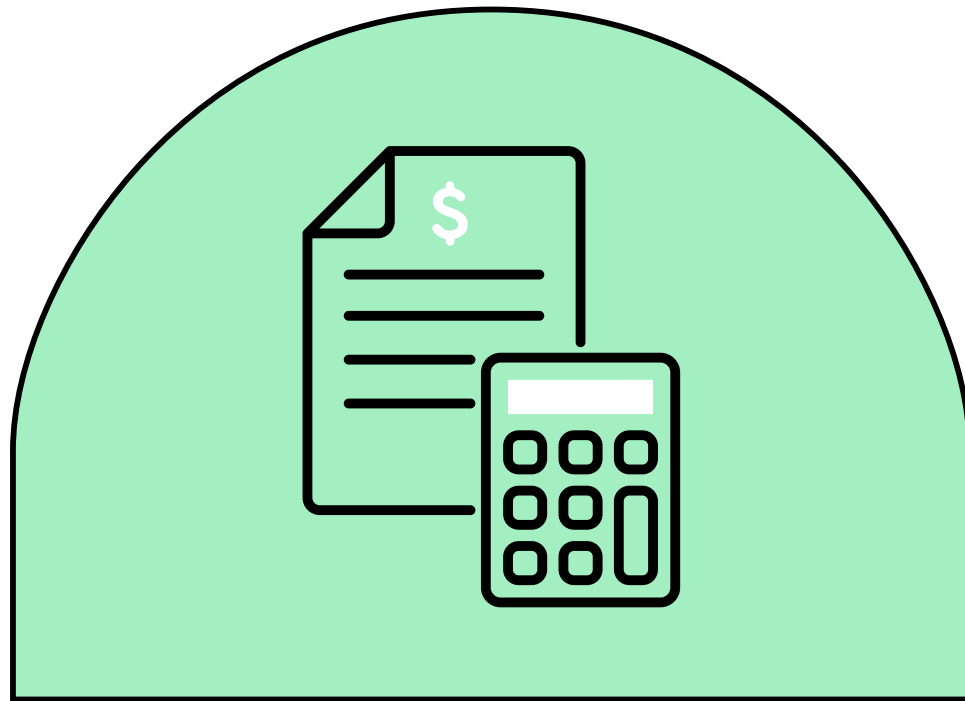
What materials are you working with? What are your ideas for your project?



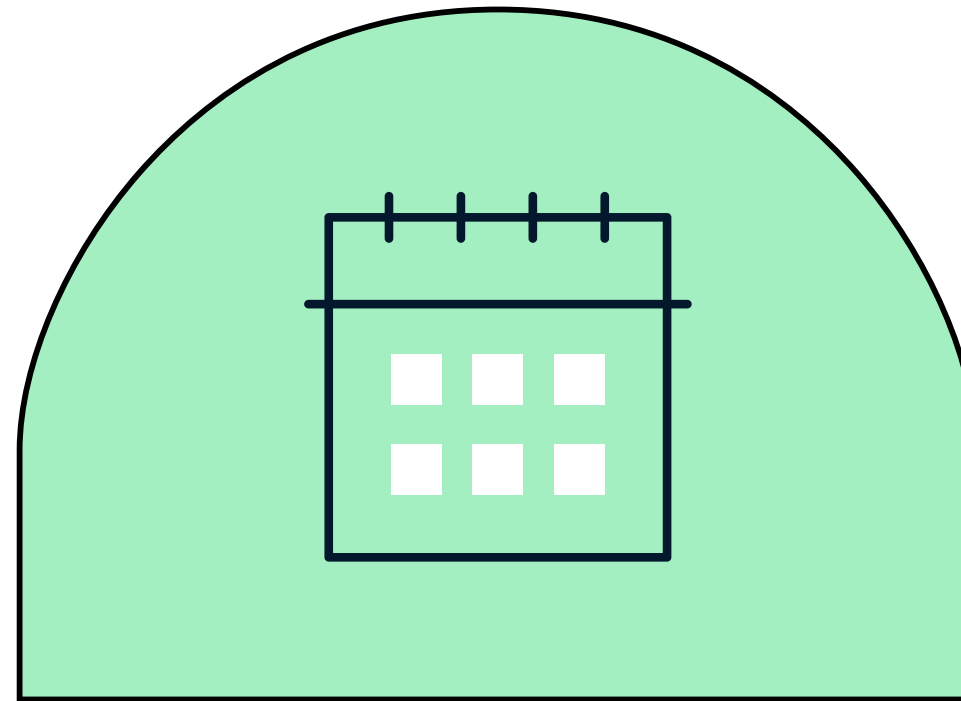
RESOURCE MAPPING

*What resources and limitations do you need to keep in
mind as you choose a tool?*

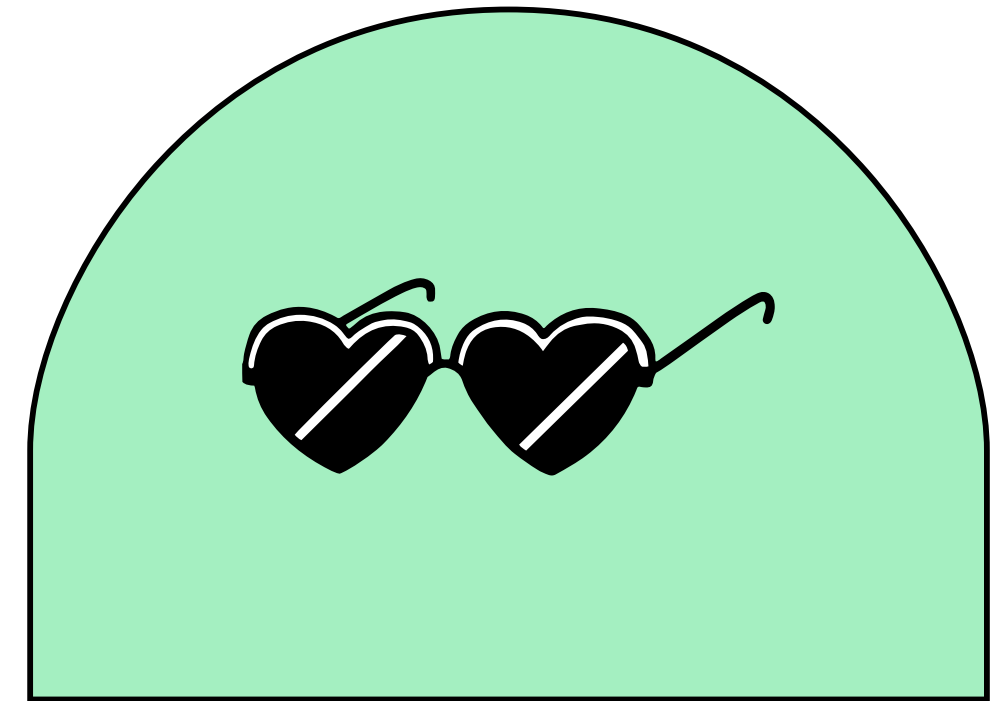
CHOOSE TWO



Inexpensive



Quick



Fancy

*EXERCISE:
RESOURCE
MAPPING*



I have more of...

I have less of...

Funding

Time

People/Labor

Training or comfort using new tech tools

Access to tools or data

Readiness of source material

Permission to use source material

NEEDS & PRIORITIES

What are your top 3 priorities?

*EXERCISE:
NEEDS &
PRIORITIES*



Needs & priorities:

Gain technical knowledge or experience	Quick to create
Privacy considerations	Free or low cost solution
Long-term sustainability	Complex or advanced functionality
Frequent updates or changes	Data/content export or download
Reaching a particular audience	Publication
Soliciting feedback or otherwise measuring engagement	Other?

ROUND ROBIN

*What discipline are you coming from? What is your
digital archive or exhibit idea?*

PLATFORM ROUNDUP

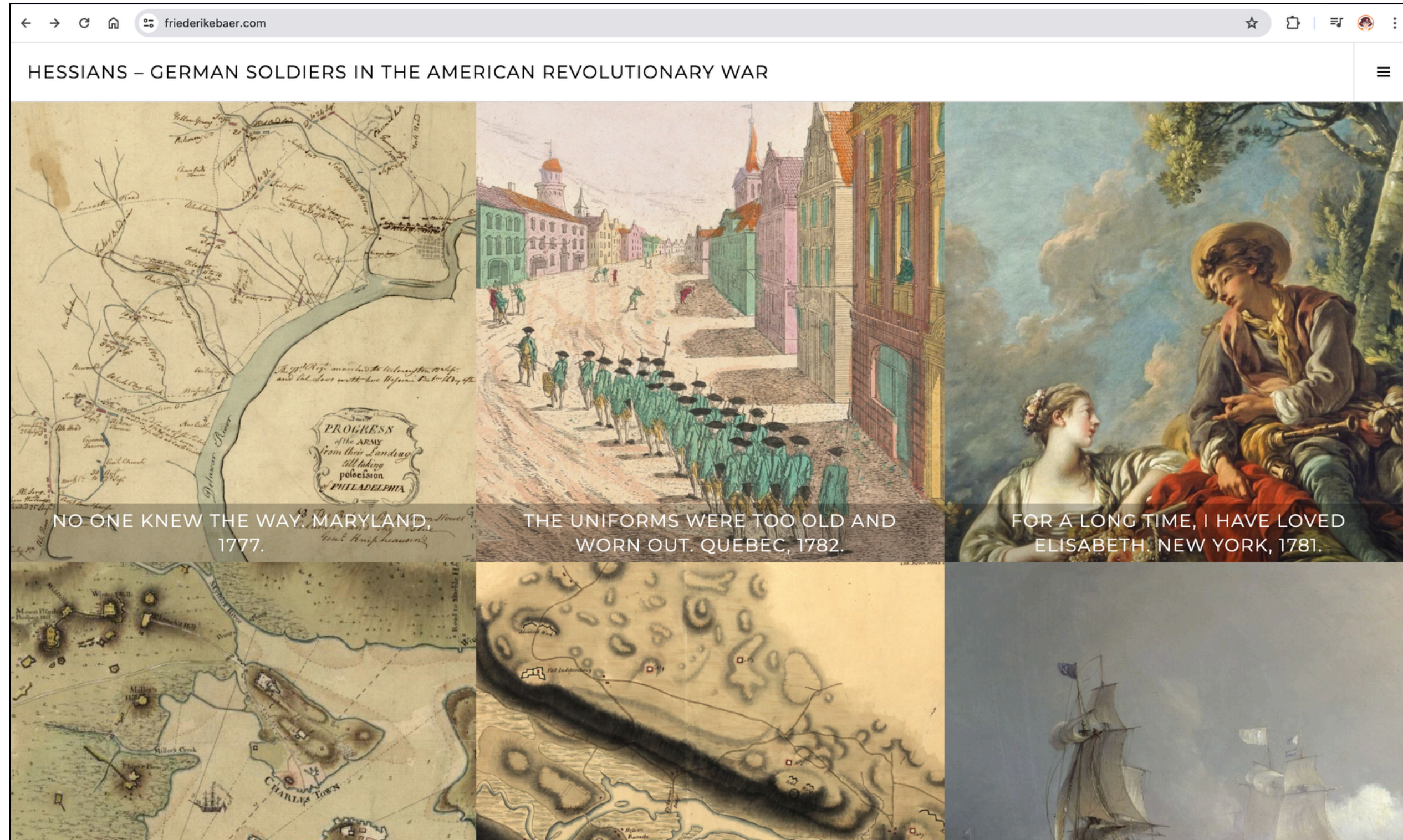
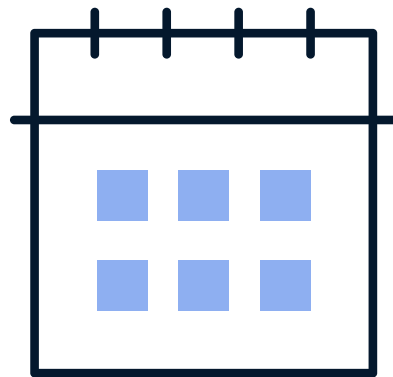
WORDPRESS

Example: Hessians - German Soldiers in the American Revolutionary War

Inexpensive



Quick



WORDPRESS

Pros

- Free (with many paid plugin and template options)
- Easy to learn and use
- If you're a Penn community member, you may be able to work with Domains at Penn (<https://domains.library.upenn.edu/>) for installation!

Cons

- Needs frequent software updates which might cause conflicts if you use plugins or extensions
- WordPress is, at heart, a blogging platform, so you may need to force it to display the way you would like
- Difficult to export in other formats for preservation

Use this tool if you...

- Need something up and running fast, but may not prioritize longevity
- Want to incorporate a blog or essay accompaniment feature
- Are eligible for a Domains at Penn account

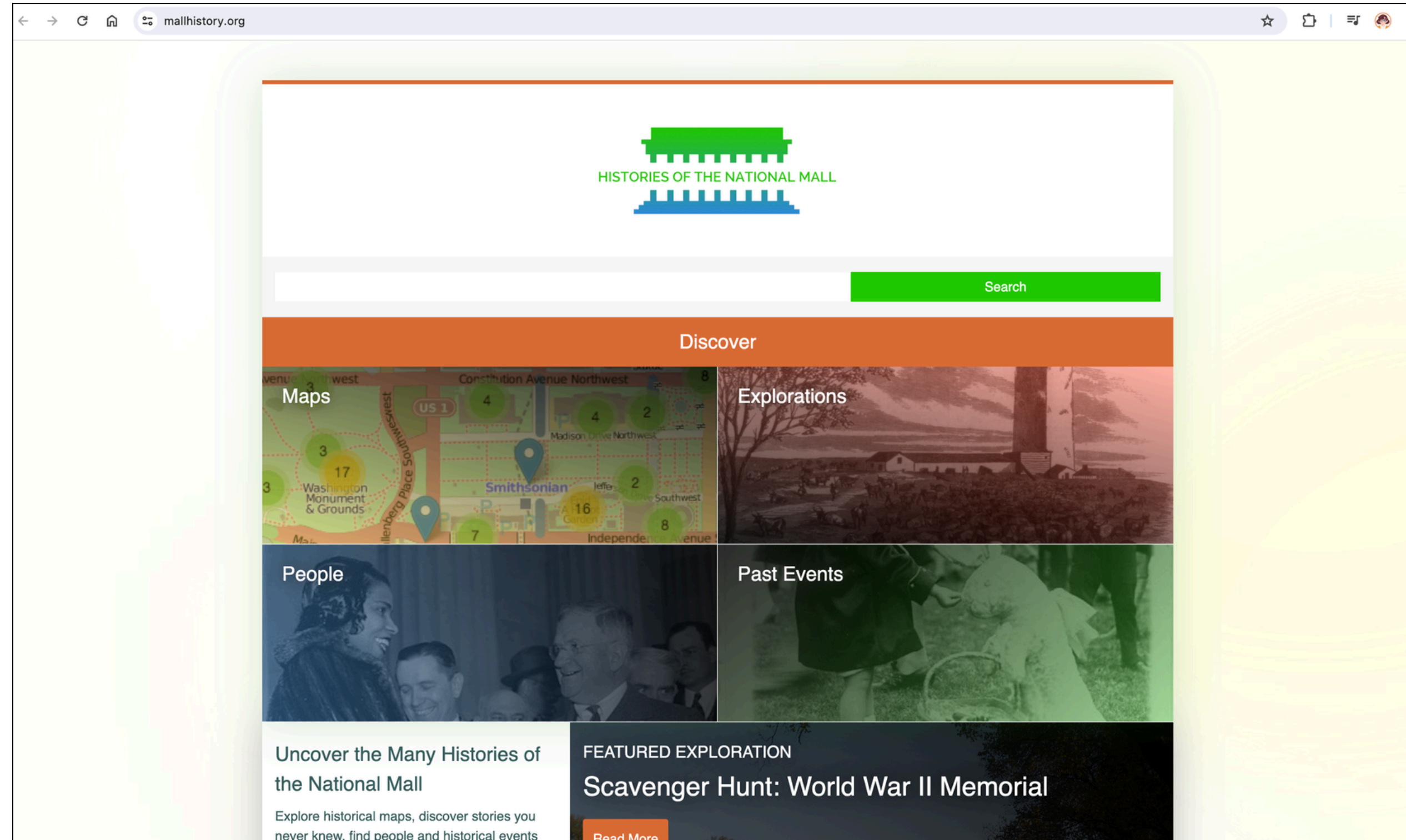
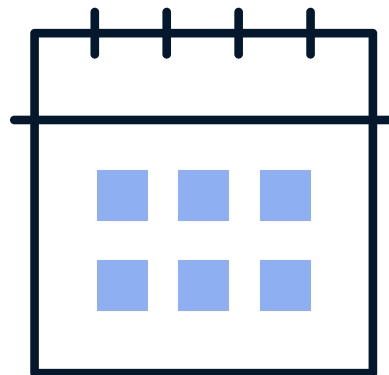
OMEKA

Example: Histories of the National Mall

Inexpensive



Quick



OMEKA

Pros

- Best for exhibits where the goal is cataloging and archiving items related to a broader collection
- Great for collecting and displaying community-sourced content (especially with plugins like Scripto)
- If you're a Penn community member, you may be able to work with Domains at Penn (<https://domains.library.upenn.edu/>) for installation!

Cons

- The central organizing feature is your items' metadata, which keeps things standardized but requires a lot of up front data entry
- Fewer aesthetic customization options
- Advanced functionality requires (often community-created) plugins which may not be frequently updated

Use this tool if you...

- Have items that are already “cataloged” or want to do it as you go
- Prioritize an archive over an exhibit
- Are eligible for a Domains at Penn account

COLLECTIONBUILDER

Example: Petrodelphia

Inexpensive



Fancy



Petrodelphia: America's First Petrochemical Corridor

Home Browse Reference Maps ▾ About ▾

Search

Browse Items

All Fields ▾ Filter ... Search Reset

Advanced Search

Sort by Date Ascending ▾

715 of 715 items

Collection ▾

Genre ▾

Location ▾



Philadelphia Gas Works [Point Breeze]

Date: 1845

Creator: Devereux, Nicholson B.,

Collection: low-angle views

Genre: image



Grays Ferry, Philadelphia, the Granite Rocks

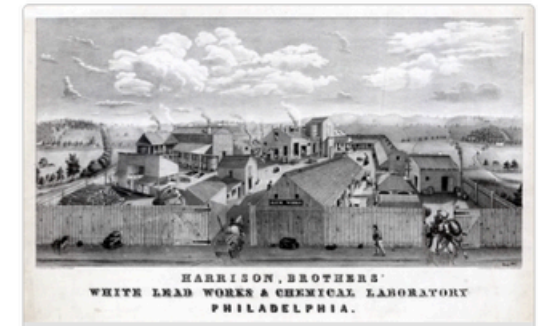
Date: 1846

Creator: Kollner, Augustus

Collection: low-angle views

Genre: image

Location: Schuylkill River



Harrison Brothers' White Lead Works and Chemical Laboratory, Philadelphia

Date: 1847

Creator: Rease, William H.

Collection: architectural

Genre: image

Location:

COLLECTIONBUILDER

Pros

- Free!
- Supports lots of file types including audio, video, and image formats
- Easy to connect items based on their attributes
- Great documentation and tutorials

Cons

- Requires self web hosting
- Some technical set-up is required at various stages of the creation and maintenance process

Use this tool if you...

- Have a number of different media types to incorporate
- Have items that are already “cataloged” or want to do it as you go
- Want to showcase connections between your items

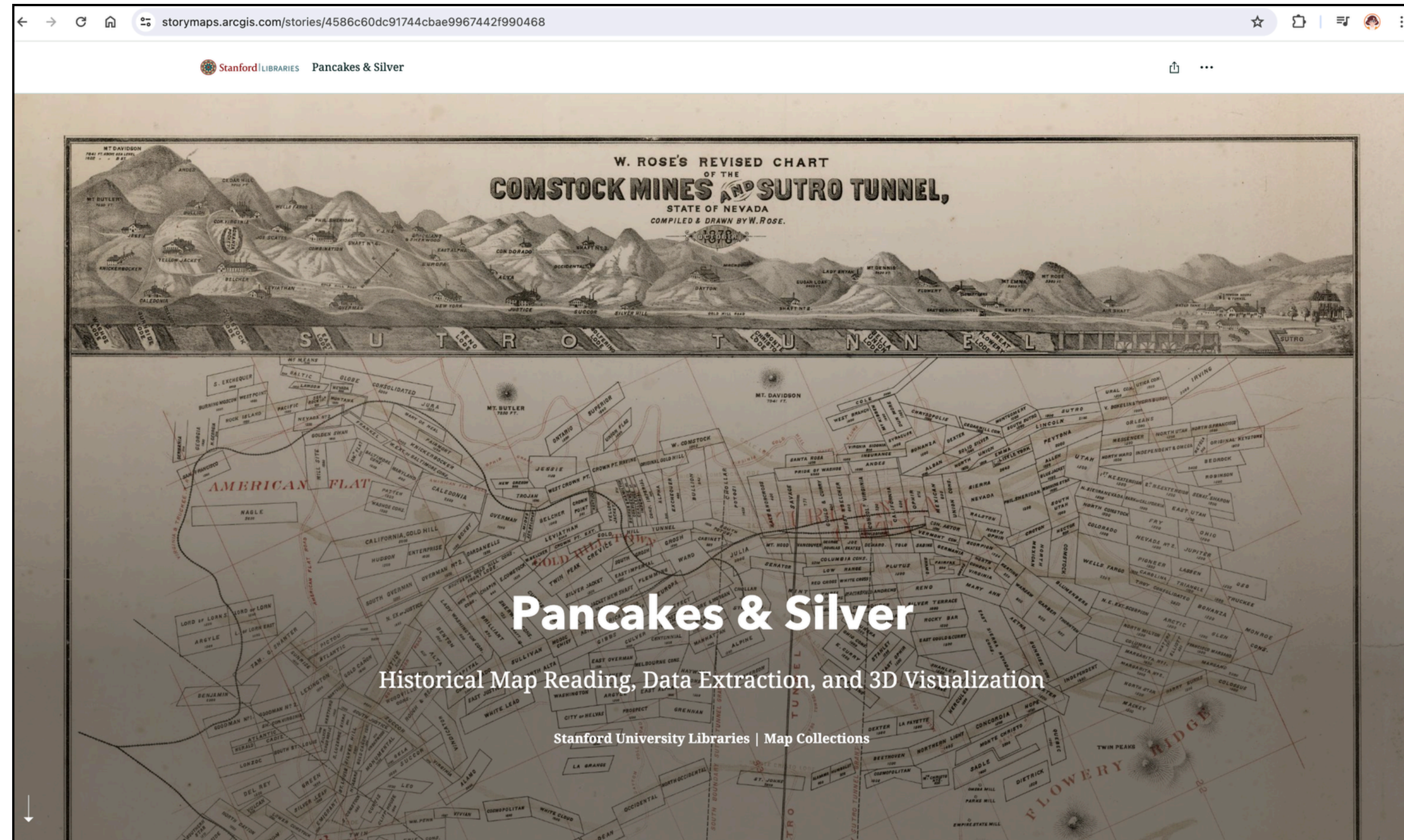
ARCGIS STORYMAPS

Example: Pancakes & Silver:
Historical Map Reading, Data
Extraction, and 3D
Visualization

Inexpensive
(for some)



Fancy



ARCGIS STORYMAPS

Pros

- Aesthetically pleasing
- Easy to use
- If you're a Penn community member, you can get free access

Cons

- Requires an expensive subscription, like the one offered by Penn
- Difficult to export and take with you if you leave Penn
- Less desirable for archives-forward projects

Use this tool if you...

- Want to emphasize storytelling or a narrative flow
- Want something that looks sharp with minimal effort
- Won't need to make updates after you leave Penn and lose access to the free account

QUIRE

Example: The Techniques of Roman-Period Glassblowing

Inexpensive



Fancy

A screenshot of a web browser displaying the website romanglassblowing.cmog.org. The page features a search bar at the top left, navigation links for 'Visual Index of Objects' and 'Table of Contents' at the top right, and a large image of a Roman glass vessel on the right side. The main content area contains the title 'The Techniques of Roman-Period Glassblowing' by William Gudenrath, followed by a paragraph of text describing the discovery of glassblowing in Jerusalem around 40 B.C. and its spread throughout the Roman Empire.

romanglassblowing.cmog.org

Visual Index of Objects < Table of Contents

The Techniques of Roman-Period Glassblowing

William Gudenrath

In Jerusalem, sometime about 40 B.C., it was discovered that molten glass could be inflated. To make this phenomenon useful and practical, manufacturing processes had to be invented. This occurred during a rapid expansion of the Roman Empire that eventually included the entire Mediterranean Basin and extended to the far eastern coast: present-day Israel. Through an extensive trade of goods and the widespread movement of people and know-how, glassblowing found its way to the Italian peninsula. It took root and developed quickly. Glassblowing spread to become—then, as now—the predominant method of making glass vessels.

A detailed photograph of a Roman glass vessel, likely a helmet or a decorative headpiece, shown in profile. It features a rounded, bulbous body with a long, narrow neck and a decorative band around the middle. The glass is a light green color with some visible wear and tear.

QUIRE

Pros

- Free and open source
- Advanced multimedia support
- Easy to convert to traditional print publication formats (like EPUBs or PDFs)

Cons

- Technical skill is required to set up and maintain sites
- Customization of design can be complicated
- Requires self web hosting

Use this tool if you...

- May want to make your project available in different formats for different audiences
- Have a budget or time to learn how to use the system

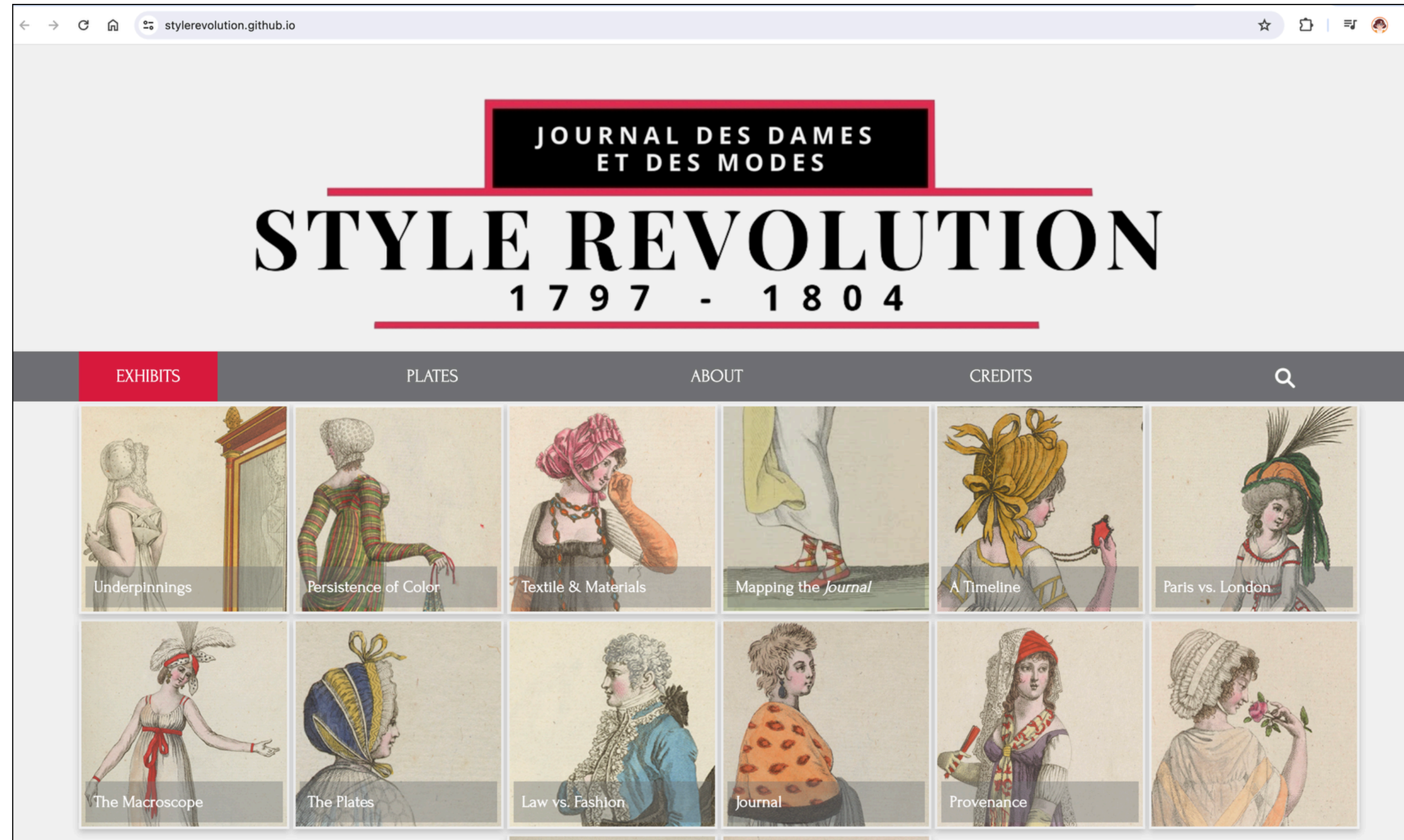
WAX

Example: Style Revolution:
1797-1804

Inexpensive



Fancy



WAX

Pros

- Supports high-quality image- or text-based exhibitions
- Easy to export files for preservation
- Incorporates minimal computing (“minicomp”) principles which can reduce the amount of maintenance required

Cons

- Requires self web hosting
- Technical skill is required to set up and maintain sites
- Customization of design can be complicated

Use this tool if you...

- Have a budget or time to learn how to use the system
- Will not need to update the project frequently upon publication

QUESTIONS
&
COMMENTS

THANK YOU!

Contact me!

- Email: heider@upenn.edu
- Book a consultation: www.library.upenn.edu/staff/cynthia-heider

Download these slides and the worksheet

- <https://github.com/cynthiaheider/choosing-archive-exhibit>

Fill out a brief survey

- tinyurl.com/rdds26

